

American Hegemony: “Peace” at What Cost

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Reihan Salam, a well-known American conservative policy analyst, believes that lasting global peace depends on the presence of a dominant power—or, in his words, “a uniquely powerful United States.” In his essay *The United States Doesn’t Spend Enough on Its Military*, he argues that the world has enjoyed more than seventy years of relative stability because of American global dominance, with U.S. military supremacy serving as its cornerstone. On this basis, Salam urges the United States to safeguard its hegemony by expanding its already substantial defense budget, in order to prevent a slide back into the great-power rivalry that led to World War I and World War II. But is that really the case?

Let us begin with a question: What was the fundamental cause of World War I? Was it territorial disputes, ideological conflicts, or clashes of faith? None of these—the answer lies in trade barriers. By the early 20th century, the great powers had divided the world into exclusive colonial markets, each shielded by high tariffs. When production outpaced what these markets could absorb and no new outlets were available, war became inevitable. Had these barriers been removed, however, a world government could have been built upon the foundation of a truly globalized market—just as the German Empire emerged from the German Customs Union (*Zollverein*).

This was exactly what the United States’ Open Door policy meant—a grand design with no precedent in history. Even at the height of the British Empire, their ambition was no greater than a “greater Britain.”^[1] But the world imagined by the United States had no borders at all,

where even European powers such as Britain, France, and Germany would kneel at America's feet. This was basically the unilateral order Woodrow Wilson pursued in his call for a "peace without victory."^[2]

To be honest, we still live within this power structure today—but is it truly reasonable? After the collapse of the Soviet Union, nearly every country acknowledged America's dominant position and granted it seigniorage from the global monetary system. In return, they expected America to provide global security, economic prosperity, and freedom of navigation. Yet every time these responsibilities clashed with America's interests, how did it choose? For others, it demands international obligations; for itself, it crowns "America First." And this brings us to the crux of the problem: Who, in the current international order, can hold the United States accountable? America plays both athlete and referee, treating world governance as its private dominion and international norms as instruments of its own expansion. As Lord Acton put it, "Power tends to corrupt, and absolute power corrupts absolutely"—and America is no exception.^[3]

In an environment lacking competition, can the United States still be trusted to fulfill its responsibilities faithfully? Consider what happened when the Great Depression struck—America abandoned the gold standard and raised tariffs by a full 50 percent.^[4] At that moment of global turmoil, the captain deserted the ship—the greatest beneficiary of World War I refused to shoulder any responsibility for the world. Had America funded a "Marshall Plan" after World War I—compensating Europe instead of forcing Germany to bear the costs—the Weimar Republic might never have collapsed, and the specter known as Hitler might never have been summoned. And today, how does the United States use tariff wars to coerce other nations? Remember this: World War I broke out precisely because nations erected ever-higher trade barriers.

Even if America could curb its power abuse, a far greater challenge persists: the international division of labor. The United States unilaterally determines the position of every country in the global market. It can elevate or crush any nation, regardless of ideology. If you were Germany after World War I, this new international order demanded your blood and flesh for its sustenance. If you were China, your role was simply that of a raw-material supplier and a dumping ground for goods. Does this seem fair? And if not, do the weak have no right to unite and challenge the status quo?

Therefore, Salam's assertion that "American hegemony equals world peace" is completely fallacious. He cleverly invokes something everyone desires—peace—and asserts that only the United States is capable of providing it. From this premise, accepting American dominance seems inevitable, and the expansion of its military appears perfectly justified. Yet the truth is that the United States, which has spent more than two centuries at war since its founding in 1776, has always been using "peace" as a mere fig leaf to mask its true intentions.[5] That is why I have no desire to see Salam's call for increased military spending become a reality.

But how, then, should the pursuit of peace truly be approached? Socialism offered an alternative path for the world's proletariat and oppressed nations: politically, by recognizing the sovereignty of each country; economically, by forging a closely interconnected community. A century ago, this path bore the name Soviet Union; today, it is called the "community with a shared future for mankind." This path has been full of twists and turns, but history shows us that falling back is easy; it is moving forward that demands a heavy price for every inch of progress.

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